

GORDON PARKS

AR

Born Black



A PERSONAL REPORT ON THE DECADE OF BLACK REVOLT 1960–1970

Steidl / The Gordon Parks Foundation







PLATE 1

FIJI: *The Girls of Adi Cakobau*. Here is the new Pacific merging with the old, for these are the girls of Adi Cakobau, the Roedean or the Vassar, of Fiji. So that I could paint them the headmistress sent several of them off to get into tapa dresses they make. We waited and waited. "I know what they're doing," she said, "they're putting oil on themselves—it's sweet-smelling and gives them a glow." Finally she had to send a girl to get them. "Tell them," she said, "that Mr McIntyre cannot paint the smell of oil!"

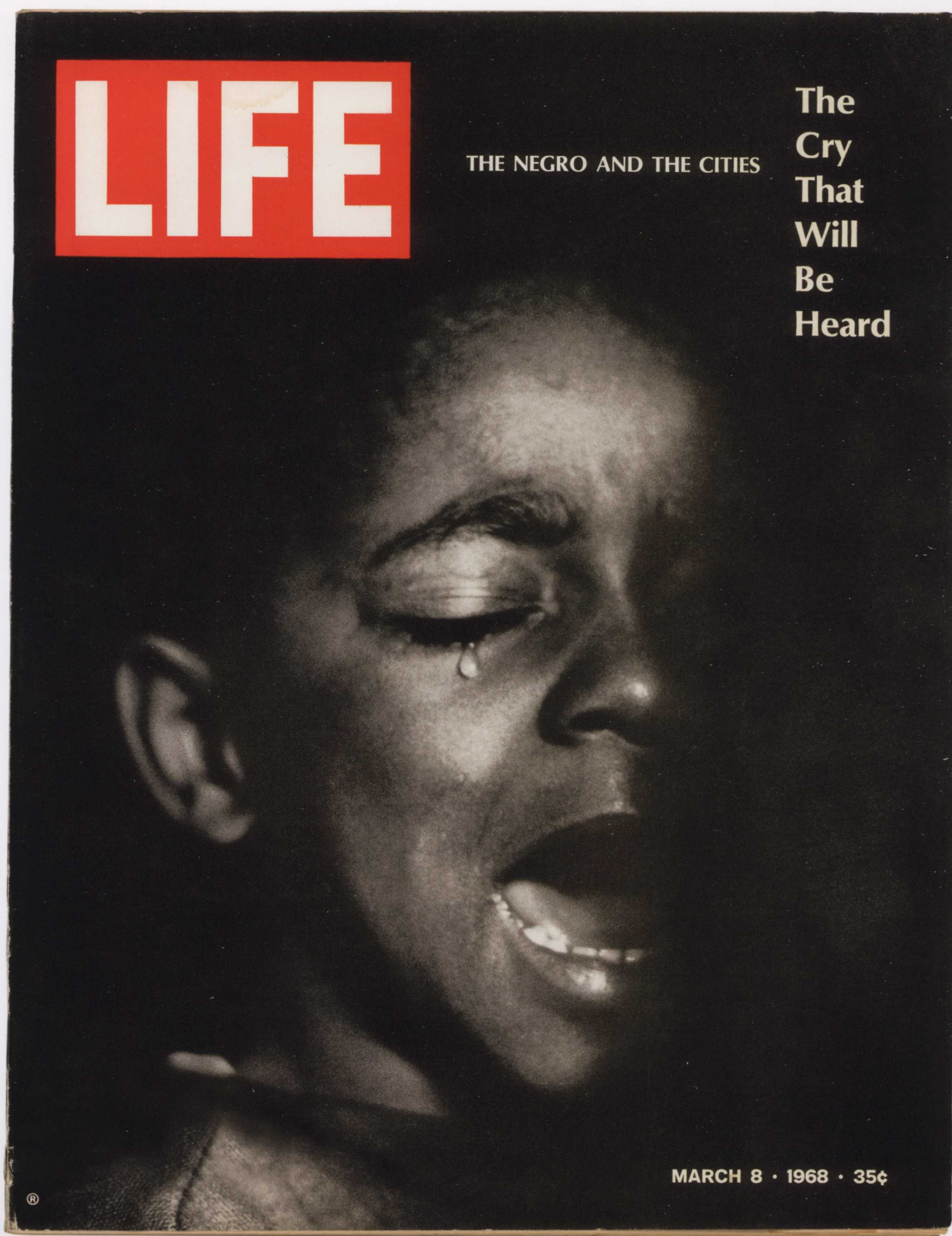
They came shyly and they were lovely. Here too was all the dignity that walks with the people of the Pacific.

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LIFE

THE NEGRO AND THE CITIES

The
Cry
That
Will
Be
Heard



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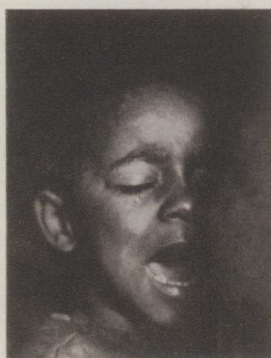
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THE EDITORS OF **LIFE** PRESENT
A SPECIAL SECTION ON

Race AND Poverty

The Negro and the cities constitute the nation's most alarming domestic problem. Yet, except when violence flares up, people ignore its appalling realities. Here are three unsparing reports from Harlem, Chicago and Brooklyn, and an analysis of the presidential Riot Commission's findings

The Cycle of Despair



For a generation, the interlocking problems of race and poverty in America have grown steadily worse, despite a score of laws and a hundred government programs and a thousand good intentions. Today it is our number one domestic crisis, and we seem paralyzed by its dimensions. As the great migration of rural Negroes seeped and then flooded into Northern cities which had no decent housing, or decent jobs, or decent schools, what once was dismissed as a Southern problem became a national one. Many Northerners, once they became minorities in their own neighborhoods, found they were not as tolerant as they thought, and began the flight to the suburbs, leaving cities to people who absorb far more tax money than they pay. Whites who had been shocked by the cattle prods and firehoses of Birmingham and Selma found their initial, belated readiness to "do something" for the Negro rebuffed by the tough militancy of a new Negro leadership, and stirred into fear by increased crime, increased talk of hate and increased violence, burnings, shooting. Still the cycle of despair—no jobs, bad housing, worse education—traps those left behind as one aid program after another fails or falls short. Still, incredibly, complacent whites and an obdurate Congress find ways to avoid and evade the problem. With this half issue LIFE lays bare the brutal ugliness of one ghetto family's existence and the aimless futility of one ghetto block. A story of one enlightened attempt to rebuild a community is followed by an assessment of this week's tough-minded presidential "Riot Commission" report which makes painfully clear how much more must be done, and at how many different levels. We begin with a black man's plea to the white community to understand and end with a former Cabinet member's plea to *all* Americans, black and white, to look within themselves for the only true solution.





Without heat on Thanksgiving, the only warmth for anyone was the turkeyless oven

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'If just one of the kids can make it in some way, I'll be thankful'

Norman Jr. and Kenneth lay on their sheetless bunks, fully clothed and under blankets, fighting the cold and their homework. Roseanna had given in momentarily to a comic book. Lette had been excused from studying. Her glasses were broken. Welfare had promised her a new pair but that had been two weeks before. Now she was having dizzy spells when she tried to read. It is Bessie who insists on homework. "Seems the most important thing now is to try to get them some kind of education," she said to me. "That's why I make them keep working. If just one of these kids can make it in some way, I'll be thankful." The way the kids keep their books so neatly stacked in all the rubble is amazing. In the quieter moments, the older ones help the others with their lessons. At such times the house seems to be filled with love.

Roseanna sat with her head buried in her hands, barefoot, with a black raincoat buttoned against the cold. She wouldn't talk to me. I walked past her into the kitchen. "Want to know what's the matter with Rosie?" Kenneth whispered. "Momma whipped her for staying out all night last night." I asked



Rosie studies fitfully in bare feet like other teen-age girls



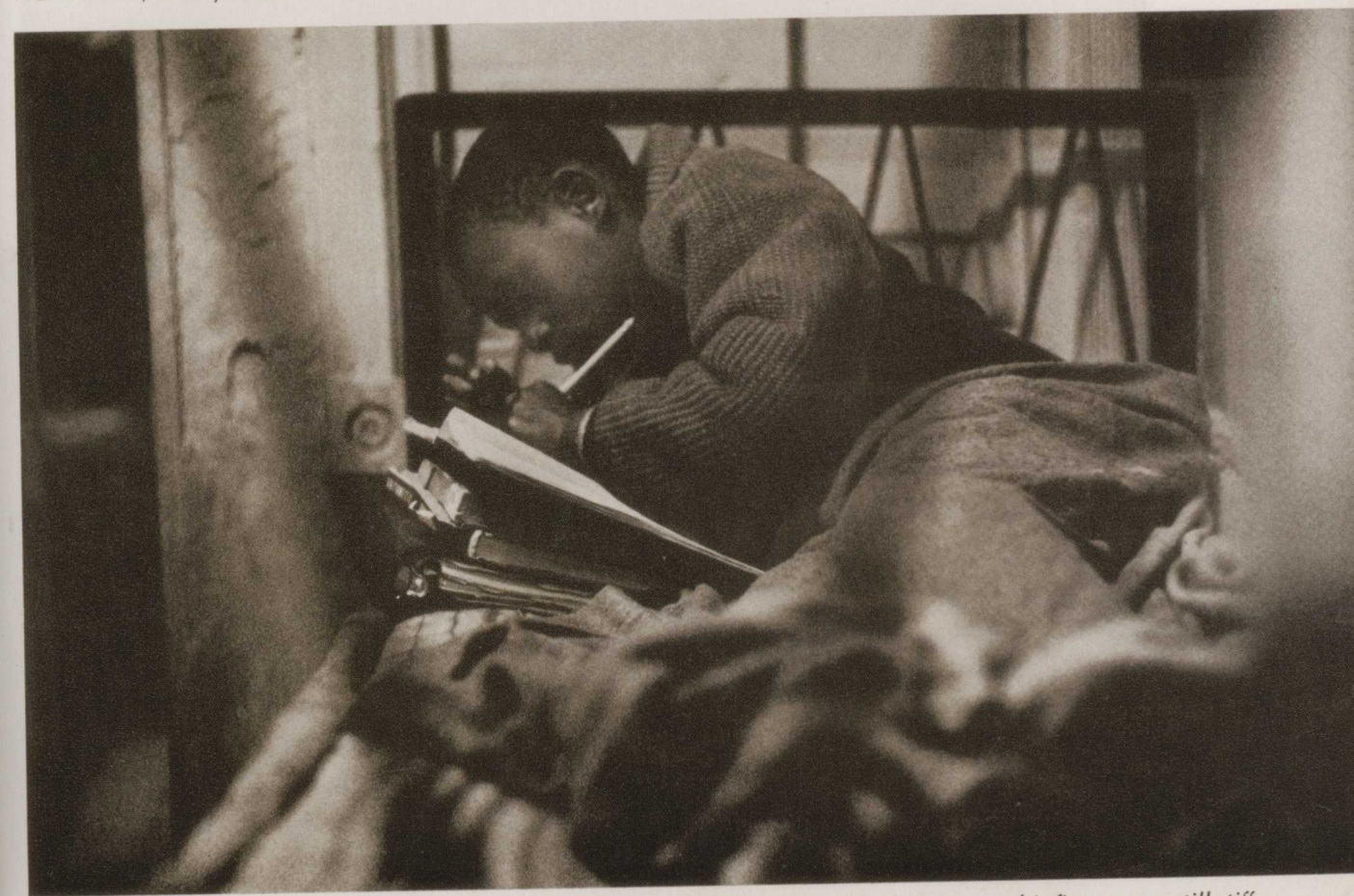
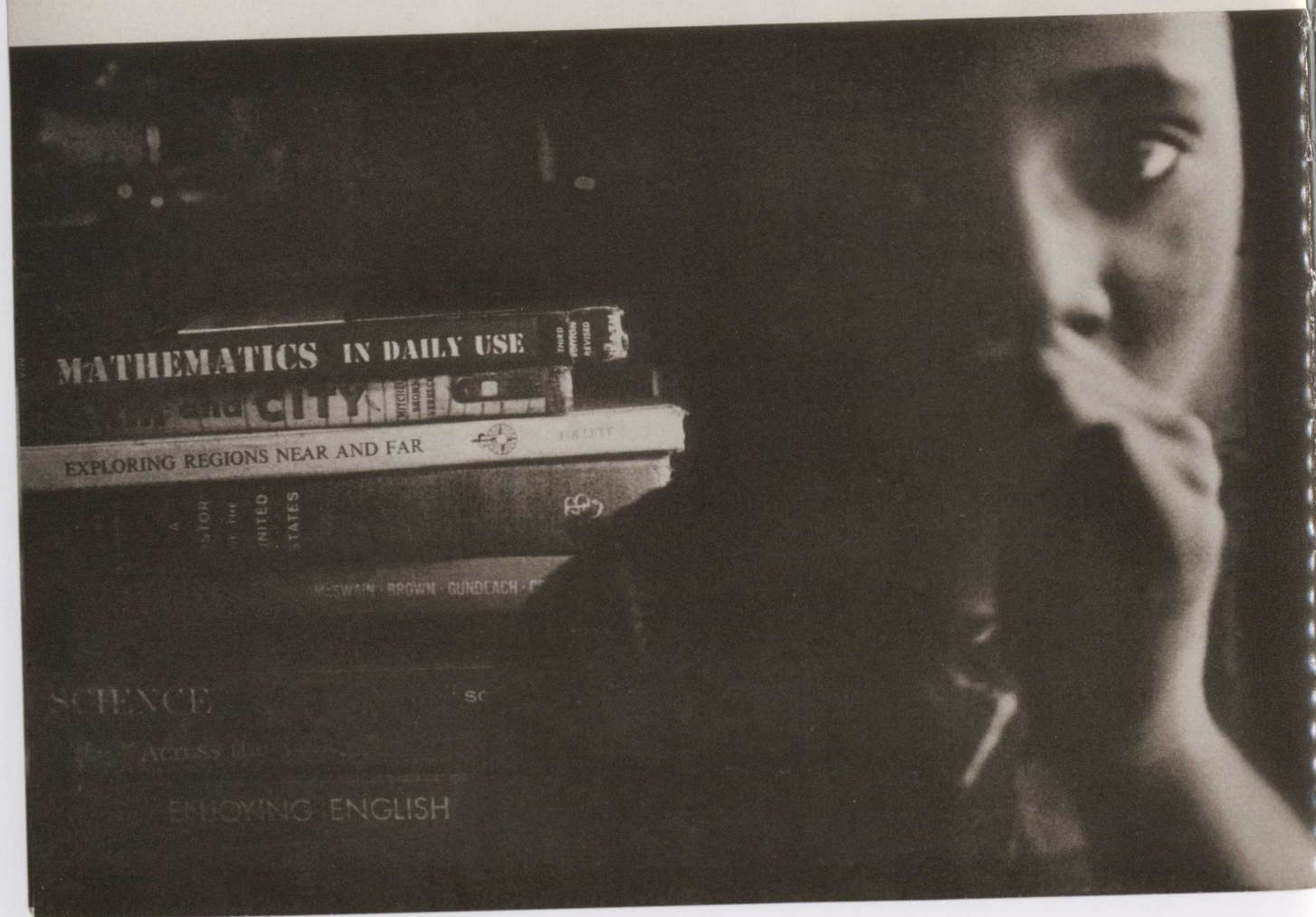
Norman Sr., barely able to read or write himself, tries helping Riel

For a few minutes the comics lure Riel and Kenneth



Rosie about it. "Us kids don't have any place to go. That particular night we were at a girl friend's house, dancing and having fun. It got so late we were all afraid to go home, so we just hung on until morning." Later, three of Rosie's friends—two boys and a girl—came

by. They sat in the semidarkness of Rosie's room on a bundle of rags and the unmade bed, their coats on, hardly saying anything to one another, sharing a single cigarette. It was as though they had come not to visit but to escape the weather and share each other's misery.



With a coat on and a blanket, Kenneth's fingers are still stiff

The books are not Ellen's but they may help her to another world



and Edridge Cleaver, and a narrative of the early life of the impoverished Fontenelle family in Harlem—have come to define Parks's legendary career as a photographer and activist. This expanded edition of *Born Black* highlights the lasting legacy of this work and its importance to our understanding of critical years in American history.

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Speech by Freedom Party Leader

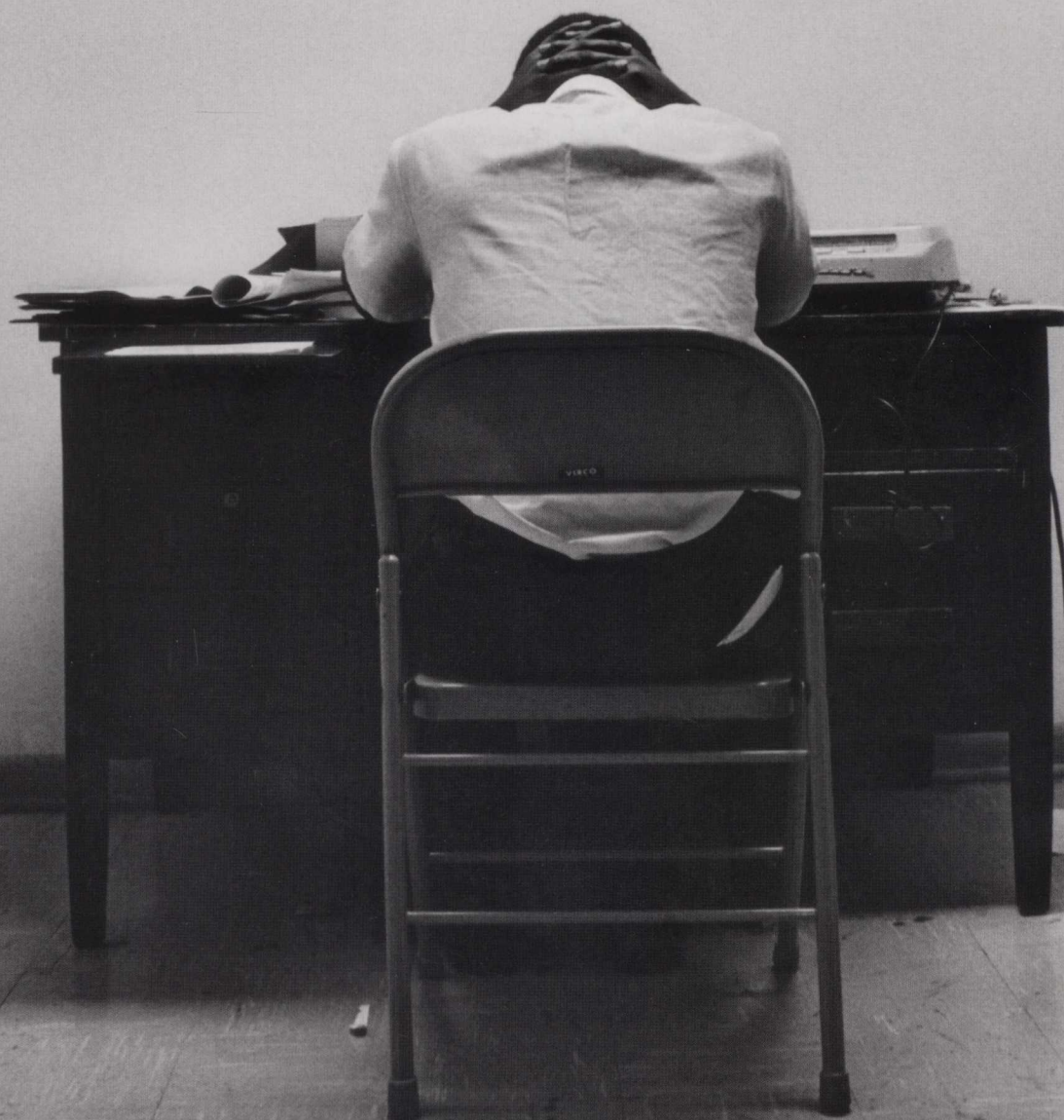


Congressional Record

By Honorable [Name]
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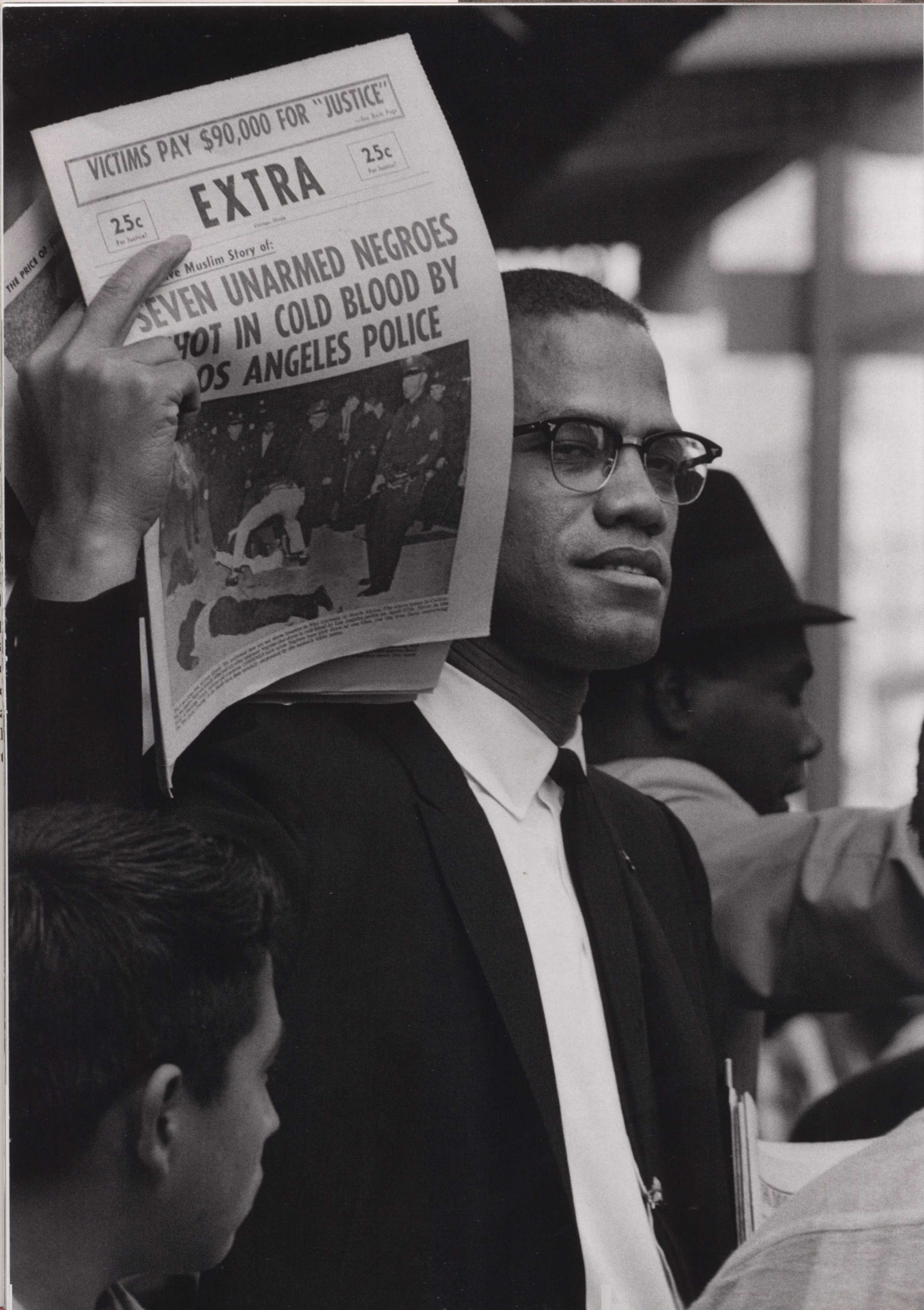
Freedom Party Platform

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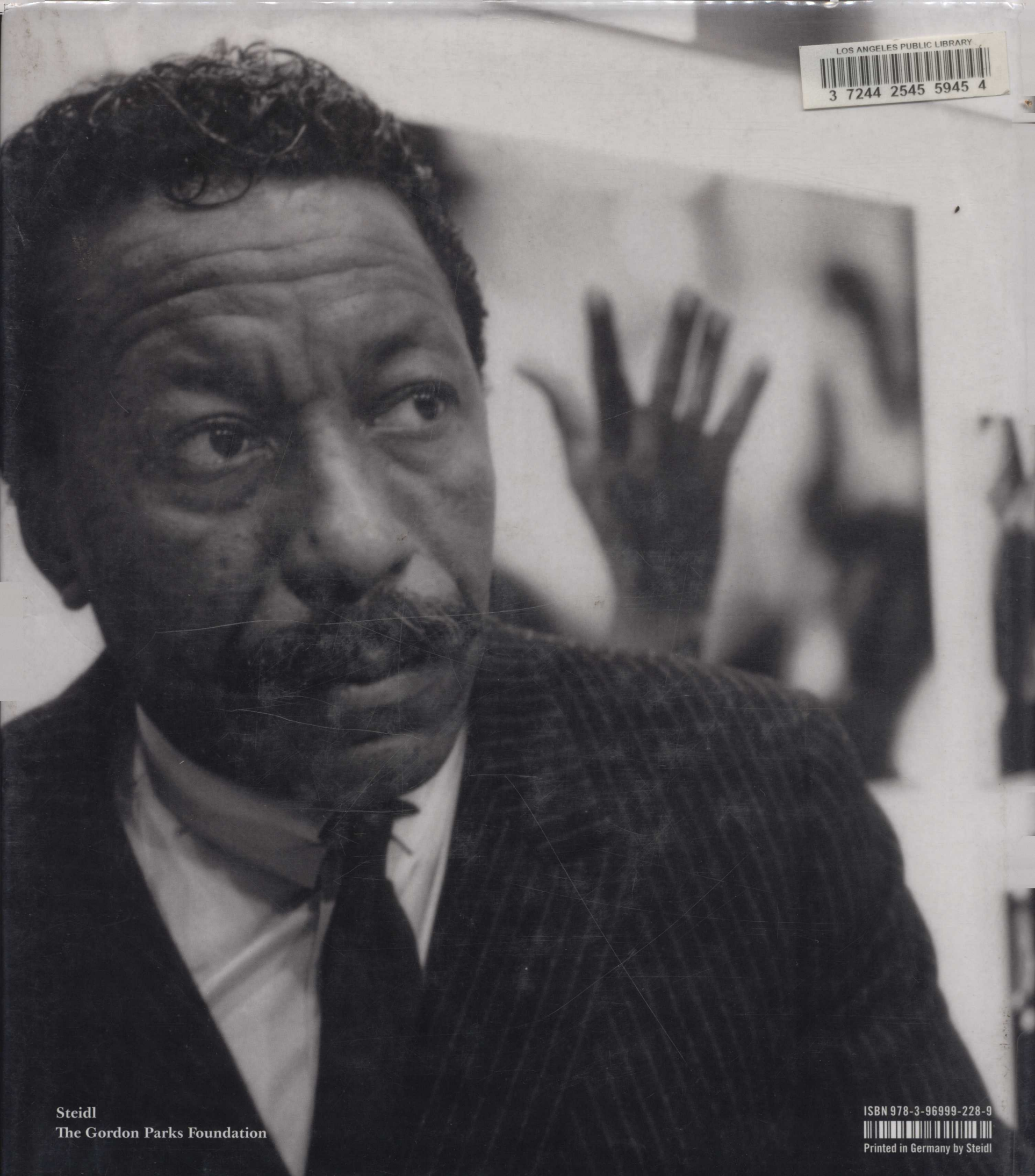
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